

How to KILL your Startup

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What you'll learn today

The 5 most proven ways to obliterate your company



Our Agenda

01	02	03
Premature Scaling: The OG company killer	Destroy your Team	Mess up your Product
04	05	06
Break your Tech	How your ego can finish the job	More bullets
07		
How to dodge the bullets?		

What do I know about this topic?

Personal Experience

I and my co-founder applied some of those strategies with success when we built our company

Investment Expertise

I've spent the last 5 years helping investors understanding what threatens their investments, at pretty much every stage (Seed, Series, A/B/C, M&As)

Some credits where it's due.

Charlie Munger "Invert, Always Invert"	Donella Meadows "System structure is the source of system behavior. System behavior reveals itself as a series of events over time"	Patrick Lancioni (The 5 dysfunctions of a team) "Ego is the ultimate killer on a team"
Daniel Kahneman "We're blind to our blindness. We have very little idea of how little we know."	Peter Senge "People don't resist change. They resist being changed".	Michal Wasilewski "Why I am not in credits?"

Premature Scaling: The OG company killer



How it Works?

Premature scaling ensures your underlying foundations are critically weak, leaving little support for the structure you attempt to build upon them.



Why it Works?

It's fueled by delusion, making you believe you're far more advanced than you are, leading to a frantic rush to the finish line, overlooking crucial steps.

Stage and Behavior

Premature scaling is the inconsistency between your actual stage and your behavior stage.

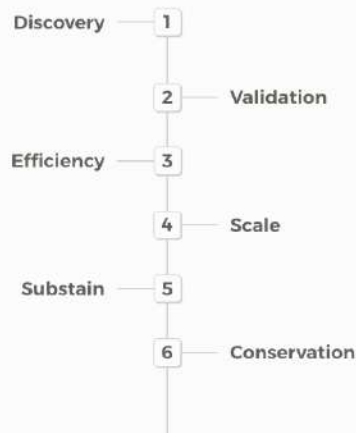
Actual stage

defined by your current customer acquisition

Behavior stage

How you behave in one of several of the dimensions

What are the stages of a startup?



Several ways to mess up (feel free to combine for compound effects)





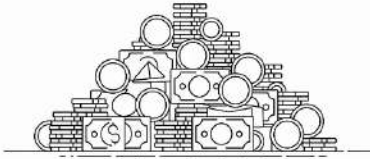


1. Finances

Will help you mess up the other dimensions faster!

Raise too much money; it will lower your discipline (we can do everything all at once with this money!) and you'll build a Frankenstein of a product in no time!

2. Business Model



Profit Maximisation



Dilution of value proposition by being everything to everyone

3. Customer Acquisition

☐ Heavy Marketing without PMF

☐ No idea who's the customer actually is

☐ Partnership Frenzy!

☐ But they keep talking about us on Techcrunch!

4. Team

Sure way to increase burn with people you don't need

Eventually some people won't even be able to do their job

Frustration & Culture Clash to the rescue!

5. Product

More Features = Better

Customers are King: Let's add anything they want: features, on-prem, and more!

6. Technology

☐ Let's make it hyper scalable cause we'll need it SOON.

☐ Fancy tech cause we're cool!



Let's vibe code our app (plus we don't need devs anymore, hurra!)



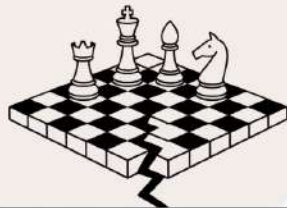
Micro-services cause monoliths are so old school.

Destroy your Team

Next to Premature scaling, making sure to mess up with your team is the best way to crash your company to the ground! Let's look into it!

Introducing...The 5 Dysfunctions of a Team!

A Great book by Patrick Lencioni



1. Trust No One. Divide & Conquer!

Strategy for Power: In a political context, "divide and conquer" (also known as "tellen und herrschen") is a strategy used to gain or keep power by intentionally causing disagreement, conflict, or division among a group.

2. Avoid conflict

We all fear conflict. Let's pretend it did not happen and just smile!



3. Don't commit & stay as vague as possible.

Otherwise people would understand their impact better and might act for a raise!



4. Avoid Accountability



7. Avoid Accountability

Dont hold people accountable. It's uncomfortable and might make you feel like an underachiever! Also OKRs are so annoying, they're for losers who don't know what they're doing!



5. Play for yourself.

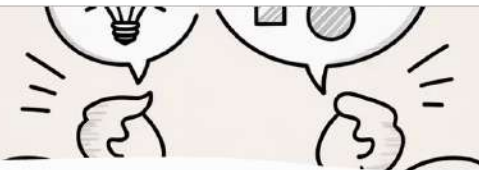
Team players slows down decision making while your gut feeling is always right!



Mess up your Product



I'm sure this is gonna work! I can feel it!



I just talked to X and he had this great idea, let's build it!



I just has this great idea in the **shower, let's build it!**

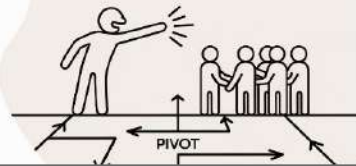
I don't have time to write this feature. It's **simple**, just build it!



We don't have time for test.
Just build it right!



Customer X said, if we build this feature **they're in!** Let's build it!



Let's tell Engineering how long it's gonna take to build this!

Hypothesis are only for people who **don't know** what they're doing!



KPIs are only for people who **don't know** what they're



KNOW what they're
doing!

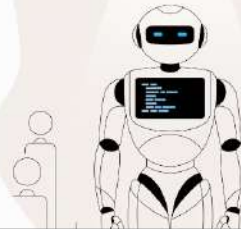


Break your Tech

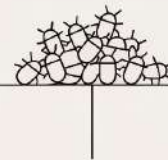


Let's **vibe code** our
production app

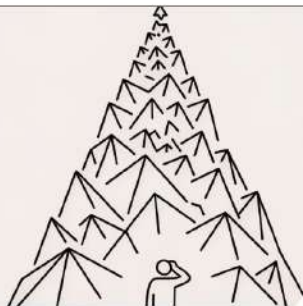
We don't need PR
reviews, ChatGPT will
look at it!



We'll see about
testing later!

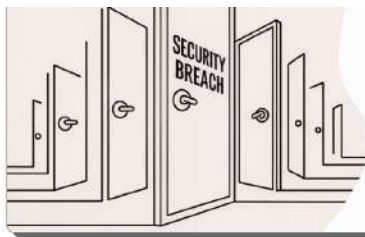


TESTING PHASE



We'll see about **Tech
Debt** later!





**We'll see about
security later!**

**We'll see about
disaster recovery
later!**

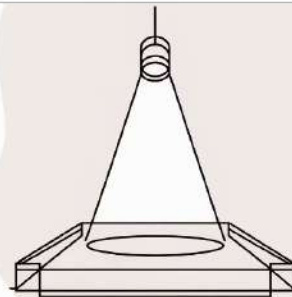


**Documentation takes
too much time, the
code is the doc!**



**Let's self host
everything, it's much
cheaper!**

Your turn!



**How your ego can finish
the job**



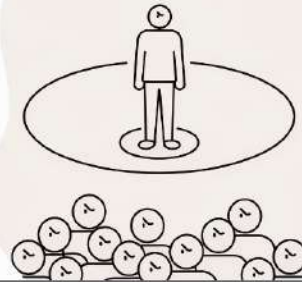


**Don't ask for
feedback. Ever.**



**Don't get mentors,
and if you do, don't
trust them**

**I am the VISIONARY.
You can't
understand.**



**It's X
fault.**



**I told you
so!**

Sleep is for the Weak!





More bullets

How to build a Toxic Culture

When all fails, toxicity will be the death by one thousand paper cuts!

1. Fear-based culture

2. Blame culture

3. Rumors & conspirations

How to Build a Hero Culture

How does not like heroes?!

1

Reward firefighting

2

Glorify individuals, ignore team work

3

Long hours = dedication

4

Punish ordinary reliability

How to Build a Mono-Culture

Let's just hire people like us, so we think alike!

1

Hire for fit, flag other perspectives as "not aligned"

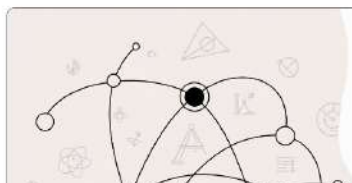
2

Avoid weirdos (and neurodiverse folks!)

3

Repress free speech and idea divergence

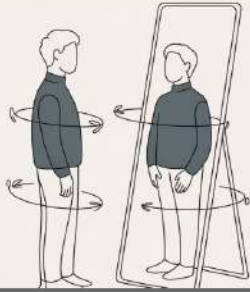
How to dodge the bullets?



Build a latticework of mental models



Learn, be curious, keep on shifting perspectives.



Always ask: Am I lying to myself?

If you don't know ask for feedback



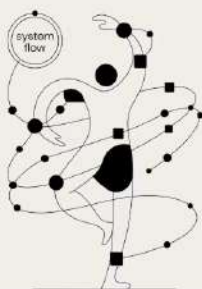
Blame it on yourself first (this is called ownership)

What did I do that my team does not feel safe to be honest?



Don't deny emotions

They make us human. They're messy, sometimes uncomfortable. Embrace instead of denying them the right to exist.



Everything is a system (even emotions).

Learn how to dance with the system (because, really the system always fight back and wins)